

HMF Design Clinic Grading Guide

Score each submitted Workbook, pain point by pain point, against a clear rubric

This is the instrument you use to evaluate the Workbook each team submits. Score every pain point across the three dimensions, out of 25, for a case study score out of 100 and an overall score out of 400. Each pain point comes with the full-credit answer and a rubric so the score reflects the quality of the team's answer. Use the Solution Guide for the wider model answers.

How answers are scored

Score each pain point across the three dimensions. Problem Identifier is worth 5, Solution Designer 10, and Value Communicator 10, for 25 per pain point. Four pain points make a case study score out of 100, and the four case studies make an overall score out of 400.

Problem Identifier **OUT OF 5**

Correctly identified the customer's pain point and the requirements behind it.

Solution Designer **OUT OF 10**

Recommended the right Cisco solution, architecture, and approach.

Value Communicator **OUT OF 10**

Clearly explained how the solution works and the customer outcomes it enables.

What each score means

Read the team's written answer, then award marks from the band it matches. These bands apply to every pain point; the full-credit answer for each specific pain point is shown beside its score box.

Problem Identifier **SCORE OUT OF 5**

5	Precisely identifies the pain point and the requirements or constraints behind it.
3 to 4	Identifies the pain point but misses some requirements or nuance.
1 to 2	Vague or partial understanding of the concern.
0	Misreads the concern, or leaves it blank.

Solution Designer **SCORE OUT OF 10**

8 to 10	Recommends the right Cisco solution and an architecture or approach that fits Cedarline and the HMF design.
5 to 7	Right solution, but light on the architecture or approach.
2 to 4	Partly right, or a product named with no approach.
0 to 1	Wrong solution, or left blank.

Value Communicator **SCORE OUT OF 10**

8 to 10	Clearly explains how the solution works and the concrete Cedarline outcomes it enables.
5 to 7	Explains how it works but is thin on outcomes, or states outcomes without the how.
2 to 4	Vague or generic.
0 to 1	No explanation, or left blank.

Grade the reasoning, not the wording. Reward answers that identify the real requirement, name the right Cisco product and approach, and explain the outcome for Cedarline. A different but well-argued product may

Working through a Workbook

Each team submits a completed Workbook. Work through it one case study at a time, scoring every pain point against the rubric and the full-credit answers on the pages that follow.

- 1 Collect each team's Workbook and check that all four case studies have been attempted.
- 2 Take one case study at a time. For each pain point, read the team's Product / platform and Solution Engineer response.
- 3 Score the pain point across the three dimensions using the rubric: Problem Identifier out of 5, Solution Designer out of 10, and Value Communicator out of 10.
- 4 Compare the answer against the full-credit answer shown for that pain point, and use the score bands to award the marks.
- 5 Add the three dimension scores for the pain point total out of 25, and the four pain points for the case study score out of 100.
- 6 Record each case study score and a line of strengths and coaching on the Proctor evaluation page at the back of the team's Workbook.
- 7 Add the four case study scores for the overall score out of 400, note what the team did well and where they can grow, and pass the topology diagram to the SME for review.

What each dimension looks for. Problem Identifier: did the team name the real requirement behind the concern? **Solution Designer:** did they land on the right product and an approach that fits Cedarline? **Value Communicator:** did they explain how it works and the outcome? Compare against the full-credit answers, and reward reasoning specific to Cedarline.

1

Case Study 1

Score each pain point against its full-credit answer and the rubric, then total the case study below.

How to award marks. Match the team's written answer to the score bands in the rubric. Full marks name the specific product and approach, identify the real requirement behind the concern, and explain how it works and the outcome for Cedarline. Award partial marks when the answer is on the right track but misses the requirement, the approach, or the outcome. Award low marks when it only restates the concern or names no product.

PAIN POINT 1 Score out of 25

Under the EU AI Act, we are classified as a 'Provider' for our internal AI systems. We need to demonstrate robustness and cybersecurity compliance to satisfy Article 15. How does Cisco help us meet these specific requirements?

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	Provider-level evidence of robustness and cybersecurity under EU AI Act Article 15.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Cisco AI Defense (AI Model and Application Validation)	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. Cisco AI Defense is specifically designed to support Provider obligations under the EU AI Act. We utilize algorithmic red teaming technology for AI Model & App Validation, which identifies safety and security vulnerabilities at scale. Outcome. It automates the technical evidence gathering required for "Conformity Assessments." By mapping AI-specific threats to standardized frameworks (like MITRE ATLAS and OWASP), it provides the documentation and continuous monitoring necessary to prove to regulators that your systems are robust and compliant.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

PAIN POINT 2

Score out of 25

We are integrating various open-source models and third-party agents into our internal workflows. How can we ensure these assets aren't introducing vulnerabilities into our environment before they even go live?

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	Vetting AI models and third-party agents for vulnerabilities before they reach production.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Cisco AI Defense (Supply Chain Risk Management)	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. Cisco AI Defense addresses this through proactive Supply Chain Risk Management. We scan your model files, repositories, and MCP servers to identify malicious or unsafe assets. Outcome. It enables "Shift-Left" security by creating an inventory of all AI models and agents. By identifying vulnerabilities before production, it prevents the introduction of malicious code or poisoned data into your ecosystem.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

PAIN POINT 3

Score out of 25

We know AI is showing up across our cloud environments faster than security can track it. We're worried we have models, agents, datasets, and MCP-connected tools running without visibility or consistent controls.

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	Visibility and consistent control over AI assets (models, agents, datasets and MCP tools) across the cloud.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Cisco AI Defense (AI Cloud Visibility)	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. That's exactly the visibility gap Cisco AI Defense is built to solve. With AI Cloud Visibility, Cisco AI Defense continuously discovers AI assets across distributed cloud environments, including models, agents, datasets, MCP servers, and agent-to-tool workflows. Outcome. Identifies rogue or unsanctioned AI assets. Maps relationships across data, models, agents, and tools.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

We're running AI workloads in cloud accounts, but we don't have a reliable way to see which models and AI assets are actually in use. We're also concerned about workloads reaching out to third-party AI models without security knowing about it. And even when we do know the traffic path, we need a practical way to inspect and enforce guardrails on prompt and response traffic in the cloud without changing every application.

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	Seeing AI assets and third-party model usage, and enforcing runtime guardrails on AI traffic without changing applications.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Cisco AI Defense with Cisco Multicloud Defense (AI Runtime Protection)	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. That's exactly what the Cisco AI Defense-Cisco Multicloud Defense integration is designed to address. Cisco AI Defense uses the integration to discover AI assets in your cloud environments and identify external AI destinations your workloads are calling. Outcome. Finds AI assets in cloud accounts. Identifies third-party AI model usage.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

Case Study 1 score PP1 ____ + PP2 ____ + PP3 ____ + PP4 ____ = ____ / 100

Strengths and coaching for this case study

2

Case Study 2

Score each pain point against its full-credit answer and the rubric, then total the case study below.

How to award marks. Match the team's written answer to the score bands in the rubric. Full marks name the specific product and approach, identify the real requirement behind the concern, and explain how it works and the outcome for Cedarline. Award partial marks when the answer is on the right track but misses the requirement, the approach, or the outcome. Award low marks when it only restates the concern or names no product.

PAIN POINT 1 Score out of 25

If a breach occurs in one of our public cloud instances, we are terrified that the attacker will move laterally into our core on-premises systems. How can we contain these threats in a multicloud environment?

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	Containing lateral movement between public cloud and on-prem in a multicloud environment.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Cisco Multicloud Defense (macro and micro-segmentation gateways)	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. Cisco Multicloud Defense leverages macro and micro-segmentation capabilities to enforce strict communication boundaries. By integrating with our Hybrid Mesh Firewall and Hypershield, we can isolate workloads and inspect traffic between cloud segments, effectively stopping lateral movement before it reaches your sensitive data. Outcome. It provides granular visibility and control over east-west traffic. By applying Zero Trust principles across the hybrid fabric, you transform your network into a series of secure, isolated zones that prevent an attacker from pivoting through your infrastructure.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

PAIN POINT 2

Score out of 25

Our auditors require proof that our security controls are applied consistently across all our cloud workloads. Gathering this data from different cloud providers is a manual, time-consuming nightmare.

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	Consistent, auditable proof that security controls are applied across all cloud workloads.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Cisco Multicloud Defense (unified logging and visibility)	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. Cisco Multicloud Defense provides unified logging and traceability. Because our security framework is integrated across the network fabric, you can generate consolidated reports that map directly to your compliance requirements (such as NIS2 or DORA) across all cloud environments from a single dashboard. Outcome. It automates the collection of evidence for security audits. By consolidating logs and policy enforcement data, you create a "single source of truth" that simplifies compliance reporting and demonstrates proactive governance to regulators.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

PAIN POINT 3

Score out of 25

We have workloads spread across AWS, Azure, and on-premises data centers. Managing security policies individually in each cloud environment is creating massive operational overhead and leading to inconsistent security posture.

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	One consistent policy model across AWS, Azure and on-prem, without per-cloud overhead.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Cisco Multicloud Defense (unified policy across public clouds)	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. Cisco Multicloud Defense, integrated within our Hybrid Mesh Firewall architecture, provides a unified control plane. You can define security policies once via Security Cloud Control and enforce them consistently across your entire distributed environment, regardless of the underlying cloud provider. Outcome. It replaces siloed, manual configuration with centralized orchestration. By abstracting the security policy from the cloud-native tools, it ensures that your security posture is uniform and eliminates the "configuration drift" that occurs when managing multiple cloud consoles.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

We have workloads on-prem, in cloud, and in mixed environments, and policy consistency is becoming difficult. Every environment feels different, and we're worried about drift.

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	Unified segmentation that prevents policy drift across hybrid and multicloud.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Cisco Secure Workload with Cisco Secure Firewall (managed via FMC and Security Cloud Control)	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. That's a common hybrid environment challenge. Cisco Secure Workload helps create a more unified segmentation model by using application dependency awareness and AI/ML-driven policy discovery to define policy based on how workloads actually communicate. Outcome. Reduces policy drift across hybrid and multicloud environments. Aligns policy to application behavior, not just static IP-based rules.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

Case Study 2 score PP1 ____ + PP2 ____ + PP3 ____ + PP4 ____ = ____ / 100

Strengths and coaching for this case study

3

Case Study 3

Score each pain point against its full-credit answer and the rubric, then total the case study below.

How to award marks. Match the team's written answer to the score bands in the rubric. Full marks name the specific product and approach, identify the real requirement behind the concern, and explain how it works and the outcome for Cedarline. Award partial marks when the answer is on the right track but misses the requirement, the approach, or the outcome. Award low marks when it only restates the concern or names no product.

PAIN POINT 1 Score out of 25

When our security tools detect a compromised device, our manual response time is too slow. By the time we identify the user and manually isolate the port, the attacker has already moved through the network.

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	Automated, real-time isolation of a compromised device, faster than a manual response.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Cisco ISE (Security Group Tags via pxGrid and Adaptive Network Control)	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. Cisco ISE integrates with your security ecosystem via pxGrid and Adaptive Network Control (ANC). When a threat is detected, ISE can automatically trigger a quarantine policy, isolating the compromised device in real-time without requiring manual intervention. Outcome. It automates the "Response" phase of the incident lifecycle. By bridging the gap between detection and enforcement, it stops threats at the speed of the network.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

PAIN POINT 2 Score out of 25

Our firewall environment has become too complex to manage manually.

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	Simplifying and cleaning up firewall policy administration at scale.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Cisco Security Cloud Control with FMC and Cisco Secure Firewall (unified policy administration)	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. Cisco applies AI-driven analysis to firewall telemetry and policy data to surface optimization opportunities, reduce manual troubleshooting, and guide cleaner policy administration. Outcome. Reduces manual policy review; identifies redundant/stale rules; lowers risk from human error.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

PAIN POINT 3

Score out of 25

Most of our traffic is encrypted, so we've lost visibility into a huge part of our environment.

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	Restoring visibility into encrypted traffic without decrypting everything.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Cisco Secure Firewall with the Encrypted Visibility Engine (EVE)	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. Encrypted Visibility Engine (EVE) uses AI/ML-based fingerprinting to analyze encrypted traffic patterns and identify suspicious behavior without decrypting the payload. Outcome. Restores visibility into encrypted blind spots; avoids the performance/privacy overhead of decrypt-everything strategies.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

PAIN POINT 4

Score out of 25

We're worried traditional signature-based detection won't catch new or unknown attacks quickly enough.

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	Detecting unknown and zero-day threats beyond signature-based detection.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Cisco Secure Firewall with Snort ML	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. That's exactly where Snort ML helps. It adds machine-learning-based detection inside the Snort 3 engine to identify exploit behavior associated with unknown/zero-day threats. Outcome. Addresses the gap between known and unknown threat detection; reduces dependence on signature timing.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

Case Study 3 score PP1 ____ + PP2 ____ + PP3 ____ + PP4 ____ = ____ / 100

Strengths and coaching for this case study

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Case Study 4

Score each pain point against its full-credit answer and the rubric, then total the case study below.

How to award marks. Match the team's written answer to the score bands in the rubric. Full marks name the specific product and approach, identify the real requirement behind the concern, and explain how it works and the outcome for Cedarline. Award partial marks when the answer is on the right track but misses the requirement, the approach, or the outcome. Award low marks when it only restates the concern or names no product.

PAIN POINT 1 Score out of 25

Network policy helps, but we also need to know what's happening at runtime inside the workload. We need better detection of suspicious behavior and policy violations.

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	Runtime detection of suspicious behaviour and policy violations inside workloads.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Isovalent Tetragon (eBPF runtime security)	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. That's where Tetragon comes in. Tetragon extends the value of Cilium by providing eBPF-based runtime security and threat detection. Outcome. Adds runtime visibility beyond basic network controls. Detects suspicious system and network behavior in real time.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

PAIN POINT 2 Score out of 25

Our Kubernetes networking feels fragmented across clusters and environments. We're dealing with too many moving parts, inconsistent policies, and too much operational complexity.

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	Consistent Kubernetes networking and policy across clusters, with less operational complexity.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Isovalent Cilium (eBPF Kubernetes networking and policy)	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. That's exactly where Isovalent Cilium helps. Cilium provides a modern, eBPF-based Kubernetes networking layer that gives you consistent connectivity, policy enforcement, and visibility across clusters and environments. Outcome. Replaces brittle, IP-centric networking models with a Kubernetes-native approach. Improves consistency across dynamic cluster environments.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

PAIN POINT 3

Score out of 25

Right now we're stitching together separate tools for networking, security, and observability in Kubernetes, and it's creating too much overhead.

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	Consolidating Kubernetes networking, security and observability to reduce tool sprawl.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Isovalent Cilium with Tetragon	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. That's exactly the consolidation opportunity Isovalent addresses. With Cilium for networking and policy, and Tetragon for runtime security, you get a more unified platform for connectivity, segmentation, observability, and security. Outcome. Consolidates multiple functions into one platform approach. Reduces tool sprawl and operational friction.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

PAIN POINT 4

Score out of 25

We know we need microsegmentation, but we don't have enough visibility into east-west flows or application dependencies to create policy safely. We don't want to break the application.

DIMENSION	FULL-CREDIT ANSWER FOR THIS PAIN POINT	SCORE
Problem Identifier OUT OF 5	Mapping east-west flows and application dependencies to segment safely without breaking applications.	____ / 5
Solution Designer OUT OF 10	Cisco Secure Workload (application dependency mapping)	____ / 10
Value Communicator OUT OF 10	How it works. That's one of the biggest reasons customers adopt Cisco Secure Workload. It gives you deep visibility into workload communication and application dependency mapping, so you can see how applications actually behave before enforcing policy. Outcome. Reveals actual application communication paths. Reduces the risk of segmentation causing outages.	____ / 10
Pain point total		/ 25

Case Study 4 score PP1 ____ + PP2 ____ + PP3 ____ + PP4 ____ = ____ / 100

Strengths and coaching for this case study

Team total and feedback

This is the same evaluation page bound into the back of every team's Workbook. Bring the four case study scores together, each out of 100 with feedback that supports the score, total for an overall score out of 400, then summarise what the team did well and where they can learn and grow.

Team _____ Members (up to 8) _____ Date _____

CASE STUDY	SCORE / 100	FEEDBACK FOR THIS CASE STUDY
Case Study 1	_____	_____
Case Study 2	_____	_____
Case Study 3	_____	_____
Case Study 4	_____	_____
Overall total	_____ / 400	

Topology diagram: SME review. The team's Hybrid Mesh Firewall diagram is submitted for Subject Matter Expert review and is not part of the score. Reviewed by SME: Yes ☐ No ☐

What the team did well

Where they can learn and grow
